

FILM-INDUCED TOURISM: AN INCIDENTAL EXPERIENCE

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This research was conducted to discover how film viewing might be related to tourism activities and whether motivations drive people to become film-specific tourists or whether visitation to film locations is simply an incidental tourism experience. A survey collected data relating to film tourism motivation, film viewing behavior, general travel behavior, and demographic profiles. Factor analysis was applied to reduce 29 statements into themes of motivations that were labeled *Novelty*, *Prestige*, and *Personalization*. Logistic regression was used to predict likely future film tourist behavior.

Key words: Motivation; Film tourist behavior; Film tourist experience

Introduction

What motivates someone to take a holiday based around a film he or she has seen? It is possible to speculate that film tourists may be motivated by elements of escape, romance and fantasy, or even a sense of vicarious experience. Cinematic images may influence consumer decision-making processes in terms of motivating visitation to film locations. An understanding of this relationship between tourism behavior and film is becoming more crucial as destinations strive to differentiate themselves in a crowded marketplace.

There has been a rapid growth of academic interest and research published in the field of film-induced tourism (Beeton, 2005; Connell, 2004; Croy & Walker, 2004; Hudson & Ritchie, 2006a, 2006b). Despite this increased academic interest in film tourism, the activities and motivations of the film-induced tourist require more attention. This

research was conducted to discover how film viewing might be related to tourism behavior and whether motivations drive people to become film-specific tourists or whether visitation to film locations is simply an incidental tourism experience.

Background

The effects of the media on audiences have been studied and debated for many years, and there have been a variety of approaches to these investigations (Bird, 2003). Concern over the social impacts of the mass media was evident as far back as the 1920s, when many critics declared that motion pictures had a negative effect on children (Wimmer & Dominick, 1994). In a historical context, the early stimulus–response model, otherwise known as the hypodermic or bullet effect, is often referred to as the dominant conceptual paradigm in audience studies (Morley, 1992). This model

suggests that ideologies (messages) can be injected into a mass audience, and direct responses could be expected from them (Couldry, 2000; McQuail, 1988; Nielsen, 2001; Taylor & Willis, 1999).

The stimulus-response model has suffered much criticism from media effects theorists for being too simplistic and not considering other variables that could have an impact on audience response and reaction. Such variables might include social and environmental conditions or personal characteristics. This theory was also criticized for focusing too heavily on the power of the media to persuade, while ignoring other environmental or personal variables (Taylor & Willis, 1999).

Many scholars believe that the expansion of mass media and consumer culture has fundamentally changed society and is therefore one of the most significant developments of the modern era (Featherstone, 1993; Shrum, Wyer, & O'Guinn, 1998). Indeed, the media is widely acknowledged as being powerful agent of socialization and, in terms of exposure, rivals many traditional socialization agents, such as parents, school, church, and community. Film, for example, provides viewers with images, accounts, and stories of life that are often far removed from the viewer's experience. It also has the potential to influence consumer perception, which can become part of enduring mental and social representations.

Beeton, Bowen, and Santos (2006) elaborate on the effect mass media has on the social construction of meaning within contemporary society and on influencing quality tourism experiences. They also support the previous argument that despite this powerful influence, individual social interactions generally have more impact than the mass media.

Media has the potential to influence general public opinions as well as playing a very important role in providing consumers with information through imagery and presentation of icons and stories that provide the consumer with a frame of reference or schema for interpretation (Hirschmann & Thompson, 1997). Feature films are often produced at locations that can gain increased popularity as tourist destinations. There would appear to be a strong correlation between the place of film production and the motivation of the tourist to visit that location. But is this necessarily the case?

Film-induced tourism can be referred to as a post-modern experience of a place that has been depicted in some form of media representation. That is, an experience that is highly personalized and unique to each individual based on his or her own interpretation and consumption of media images (Beeton, 2005; Macionis, 2005).

The influence of media on the travel decision-making process has been examined by various researchers (Butler, 1990; Echtner & Ritchie, 1991; Hunt, 1975), who have suggested that consumers receive information about potential destinations via a range of media. This information enables the consumer to construct their own interpretations or images that form the basis of their destination choices. Films, in particular, play a very significant role in influencing people's mental images and perceptions of a destination.

Butler (1990) argues that films have the potential to be more influential to consumers than printed sources of information (e.g., brochures) because they are perceived to have higher levels of credibility and do not carry the same perceived bias as promotional material. It is thus recognized that film can enhance awareness of destinations and affect the decision-making process of consumers (Schofield, 1996).

To further understand film-induced tourism, it is appropriate to examine the motivations of the film-induced tourist. The study of consumer motivation generally involves understanding the interrelationships between motives and specific behavior. Tourism motivation acts as a trigger that sets off all the events involved in travel (Parrinello, 1993). It can be defined as "a meaningful state of mind which adequately disposes an individual to travel, and which is subsequently interpretable by others as a valid explanation for such a decision" (Dann, 1981, p. 205).

By investigating internal drivers of film-induced tourism, it is anticipated that there are a range of possible motivations that come into play and might include ego enhancement, fantasy or escape, status or prestige, search for self-identity, or vicarious experience. Tourists may be drawn to film sites for more personal motivations, such as reliving nostalgic memories from childhood, for example, as in the generational favorite *The Sound of Music*, which then becomes a sentimental jour-

ney, or visiting Notting Hill (Busby & Klug, 2001) for romantic notions.

A critical internal driver, or motivation, is the "tourist gaze" in terms of film constructing a gaze for an individual to observe (Urry, 1990). Couldry (1998) proposes the motivation of pilgrimage and labels film-induced tourists as "media pilgrims" who are fulfilling the motivation to "gaze" on sites they have seen on screen. Beeton (2005) also suggests that film tourism is about tourists looking for the sites, experiences, and even the fantasies portrayed by films. This introduces the intangible elements of the tourist experience based on individual motivating factors, such as fantasy. Riley and Van Doren (1992) emphasize that the attractions seen in films "are not only associated with the allure of picturesque physical environments, but also for reasons of pilgrimage, escape and nostalgia" (p. 268).

Conversely, some films may have a negative effect on tourism where the films have produced "undesirable imagery" and subsequent negative destination images. Such undesirable images can be created by negative film storylines, such as crime and violence, and may lead to misinterpretation, causing damage to consumer perception and influencing potential decisions (Beeton, 2005).

Method

To discover whether film viewing motivates people to become film-specific tourists or whether visiting film locations is simply an incidental tourism experience, a survey instrument was developed. Data relating to film tourism motivation, film viewing behavior, general travel behavior, and demographic profiles were collected.

A range of information including 29 motivational statements drawn from the literature and previously conducted in-depth interviews was obtained. The critical themes that emerged from these interviews are consistent with the literature and previous findings of film tourism motivation; this can be seen in Table 1.

Respondents were asked to indicate the extent to which they agreed with each of the 29 statements on a 5-point Likert scale. Each statement began with the words, *For me, the main reasons for traveling to film locations would be . . .* and

Table 1

Film Tourism Motivation Themes

Theme	References
Personal connection with film	Beeton, 2005; Couldry, 1998; Kim & Richardson, 2003; Macdonis, 2004; Riley, Baker, & Van Doren, 1998; Sharpley, 2003
Scenery/landscape	Kim & Richardson, 2003; Riley & Van Doren, 1992; Urry, 1990
Entertainment value	Pearce, 2005
Unique experience	Crompton, 1979; Hall & Weiler, 1992
Celebrity	Beeton, 2005; Maltby, McCutcheon, Ashe, & Houran, 2001; Pearce, Morrison, and Moscardo, 2003; Rojek, 2001
Status symbol	Crompton, 1979; Dann, 1981; MacCannell, 2002; Riley, 1995.

ended with a reason, such as *To have a unique experience* or *To fulfill a personal dream*. Open-ended questions about activities, experiences, and behavior of respondents related to film tourism were included.

A random sample of 2,000 was drawn from a national mailing list of people who had indicated a specific interest in both cinema and travel pursuits. Surveys were mailed out to the sample. A total of 668 usable surveys were returned, representing a response rate of 33%. This is a good response rate for mail surveys where the modal return rates lie between 20% and 40% (Green, Tull, & Albaum, 1988).

First, descriptive statistics were generated for demographic and trip variables, and means were calculated for the responses to the film tourism motivation statements. Second, the 29 statements representing film tourism motivations were tested using principal components factor analysis, where three independent themed factors became evident.

Logistic regression was used in the final stage of the data analysis to identify a predictive model of future film tourist behavior.

Findings

Descriptive information from the sample used in this study is presented in Table 2. The gender category presented a clearly female-dominated

Table 2
Demographic Profile of Respondents

Variable	Frequency	Percent
Gender (<i>n</i> = 664)		
Male	114	17.2
Female	550	82.8
Age		
Under 20	8	1.1
20–29	196	29.7
30–39	197	29.9
40–49	142	21.5
50–59	91	13.8
60 years+	24	4
Relationship status (<i>n</i> = 663)		
Single	178	26.8
Separated	62	9.4
Married	289	43.6
De facto	127	19.2
Education (<i>n</i> = 662)		
Completed year 10 or less	78	11.8
Completed year 11 or 12	137	20.7
Technical certificate/diploma	162	24.5
Trade qualification	20	3
Undergraduate degree	157	23.7
Postgraduate degree	79	11.9
Occupation (<i>n</i> = 664)		
Professional	151	22.7
Clerical	98	14.8
Sales/retail	52	7.8
Tradesperson	17	2.6
Manager	77	11.6
Student	48	7.2
Home duties	92	13.9
Retired	27	4
Unemployed	13	1.9
Income (AU\$) (<i>n</i> = 650)		
<\$20,000	69	10.6
\$20,001–35,000	74	11.4
\$35,001–50,000	137	21.1
\$50,001–65,000	110	16.9
\$65,001–100,000	152	23.4
\$100,000+	108	16.6

sample population with females representing 80%. Age distribution of respondents indicated that the majority of respondents were aged between 30–39 years, followed by 20–29 years category. The majority of respondents were married.

The main component of this study examined film-induced tourism motivations and behavior by asking respondent agreement to a series of Likert scaled statements. As can be seen in Table 3, the top five motivational statements were:

- to see the scenery and landscape in real life,
- to have fun and feel entertained,
- to add something special to my holiday,

- to experience something novel and new, and
- to have a unique experience.

The mean score ranking of items shows that motivations such as fantasizing about being in a film or feeling close to favorite movie star rated the lowest scores. Thus, in terms of this ranking, respondents indicated they were more interested in the novelty of film tourism and experiencing something different, as well as simply having a good time.

A range of responses were given when respondents were asked for reasons they had visited film locations. Content analysis of the open ended questions revealed 24% of respondents indicated that the reason for visiting a film location was because they were on holiday and it was part of their holiday experience. “We wanted to backpack around New Zealand, then we ended up attending the world premiere and stopping at some film locations while we travelled” (185: female, 21 years).

The second most frequent reason provided by respondents as to why they had visited film locations was to see specific sites and locations from a film (14.8%). “We wanted to see where the film was made to see what it was like in real life” (348: male, 40 years).

The third reason for visiting a film location was as a side trip while on an organized holiday (14.3%). Nine percent of respondents wanted to see for themselves the scenery backdrops that they had seen in films. The physical place of the film was important to these respondents.

When asked whether they had ever been on a holiday that included a visit to a film location, 70% of respondents indicated they had not. Thus, only 30% of total respondents, or 195 individuals, could answer a series of probing questions about visiting film locations. When probed as to whether they had ever visited a film location with the *prime reason* being to visit that film site, only 15% of those whose holiday had included a visit to a film site, or 28 individuals, said yes; the remainder (85%) said that the main reason for travel had not been film-related. Therefore, only 4% of the total sample could be considered dedicated or specific film tourists.

The 29 motivation items were subjected to exploratory factor analysis. Three themes of motiva-

Table 3

Rank Ordered Means of Film-Induced Tourism Motivational Items

Rank	Item	Mean	SD	<i>n</i>
1	To see the scenery and landscape in real life	4.15	0.74	654
2	To have fun and feel entertained	4.03	0.73	654
3	To add something special to my holiday	4.03	0.75	654
4	To experience something novel and new	3.91	0.75	654
5	To have a unique experience	3.85	0.87	654
6	To escape from the ordinary	3.83	0.86	654
7	To experience the film location	3.69	0.91	654
8	To have a satisfying tourism experience	3.65	0.88	654
9	To take photos at the film sites	3.62	0.99	654
10	To see behind the scenes of the film	3.43	1.08	654
11	To talk about it when I returned home	3.33	1.08	654
12	To reminisce about the film	3.32	0.99	654
13	To get a sense of the film's atmosphere	3.27	1.02	654
14	To feel excited to be on a film site	3.09	1.16	654
15	To gain firsthand experience with the film	3.06	1.04	654
16	To feel the romance and nostalgia of film	2.99	1.05	654
17	To go to famous places my friends haven't been to	2.96	1.12	654
18	To relive the scenes from the film	2.93	1.05	654
19	To buy film memorabilia/souvenirs of the location	2.92	1.09	654
20	To make a personal connection with the film	2.91	1.07	654
21	To make a pilgrimage to sites seen on film	2.84	1.04	654
22	To bring the film to life (make it real)	2.82	1.12	654
23	To bathe in the glory of having been there	2.81	1.16	654
24	To fulfill a personal dream	2.68	1.17	654
25	To experience personal growth by visiting the site	2.63	1.09	654
26	To personally experience the storyline of the film	2.59	1.06	654
27	To fantasize that I was in the film	2.19	1.08	654
28	To feel close to my favorite actor	2.15	1.05	654
29	To fantasize that I was an actor in the film	1.98	0.99	654

tional forces were found (see Table 4), and labeled Personalization, Novelty, and Prestige, consistent with tourism motivation literature (Crompton, 1979; Dann, 1981; Iso-Ahola, 1982; Smith & Croy, 2005).

Personalization relates to a sense of personal involvement with film and fantasy aspects of film. Novelty relates to having a unique or novel experience by visiting film locations. Prestige relates to the inherent status symbol of film tourism.

Composite scales were computed by averaging the number of items comprising the scale and reliability coefficients computed. It appears that elements of having a unique and novel experience, associated with visiting film locations, were the strongest motivators (see Table 5). Indeed, because of the niche nature of film tourism itself, visiting such locations by nature is unique and novel. The motivation of prestige and status achieved through visiting film locations and being able to brag about it to friends was slightly less

important to respondents, followed by personalization motivations associated with film.

The final stage of the data analysis involved an attempt to identify a parsimonious, multivariate predictive model of future film tourism group membership (would you like to travel to locations related to any films you have seen?). Motivational factors together with past behavior were thought to be useful predictors of future film tourism group membership. An inspection of bivariate correlations revealed each of the motivational factors and past behavior were significantly correlated with future behavior.

Given that the dependent variable and one of the predictor variables were categorical in nature (i.e., yes/no), logistic regression was employed to further analyze the data (Tabachnick & Fidell, 2001). Four variables (personalization, novelty, prestige, and past film tourism—yes/no) were included in a binary logistic regression model to pre-

Table 4
Order (by Size of Loadings) in Which Variables Contribute to Factors

Factor	Factor Loading	Eigenvalue	Variance Explained
1. Personalization		6.47	25.9
Personally experience storyline of film	0.798		
Bring film to life (make it real)	0.736		
Make personal connection with film	0.732		
Fantasize I was an actor in film	0.730		
Feel close to my favorite actor	0.711		
Fantasize I was in the film	0.694		
Feel romance/nostalgia of film	0.685		
Get a sense of the film's atmosphere	0.662		
Gain firsthand experience of the film	0.628		
Relive scenes from the film	0.610		
Make a pilgrimage to sites seen on film	0.596		
Experience personal growth by visiting site	0.556		
Fulfill a personal dream	0.543		
2. Novelty		4.48	17.9
Have a unique experience	0.736		
Have fun and feel entertained	0.732		
Experience something novel and new	0.704		
Add something special to my holiday	0.695		
See scenery/landscape in real life	0.633		
Have a satisfying tourism experience	0.619		
Escape from the ordinary	0.619		
3. Prestige		3.19	12.8
Talk about it when return home	0.786		
Go to famous places friends haven't been to	0.765		
Bathe in glory of having been there	0.763		
Buy film memorabilia/souvenirs	0.445		
Take photos at film sites	0.443		

dict future film tourism group membership (correlation between variables < 0.62). Diagnostic tests revealed collinearity was not a problem, tolerance statistics were all above 0.1 and VIF statistics were all below 10.

The predictors were entered using SPSS's stepwise forward entry method, with the past behavior variable designated as a categorical predictor (see Table 6). The regression model was significant, $\chi^2(3) = 84.36, p < 0.001$. Though the base model correctly classified only 53% of subjects into fu-

ture film tourism groups, the final model correctly classified 65% of subjects (and correctly classified approximately 70% of those likely to take a film tourism holiday in future). Three of the four predictors explained significant amounts of unique variance in the criterion.

The Hosmer and Lemshow statistic is not significant, suggesting the model predicts real-world data reasonably. Thus, it can be concluded that membership of the *likely to take a film tourism holiday in future* group was most probable among those respondents who (1) had taken a film based holiday in the past, (2) had high novelty motivations, and (3) had high personalization motivations. The prestige motivation factor was not significant in predicting group membership.

Table 5
Motivation Dimensions Rank Order by Mean

Rank	Dimension	Mean	SD	Alpha
1	Novelty	3.92	0.588	0.859
2	Prestige	3.12	0.829	0.819
3	Personalization	2.69	0.775	0.926

5-point scale, where higher scores indicate higher levels of importance.

Discussion

The results indicate that for the vast majority of tourists, film can only be considered a secondary motivator or contributing factor, not a main or pri-

Table 6
Summary of Logistic Regression Analysis Predicting Future Film Tourism Group Membership

Predictor	B	SE B	Wald (<i>df</i> = 1)	exp b (95% CIs)
Constant	-3.47	0.69	25.51***	0.03
Past holiday	-0.77	0.19	16.53***	0.46 (0.32–0.67)
Novelty motivation	0.67	0.19	12.02**	1.96 (1.34–2.88)
Personalization motivation	0.56	0.14	15.95***	1.74 (1.33–2.29)

Regression coefficients are after the final step. $R^2 = 0.12$ (Cox & Snell), 0.16 (Nagelkerke). Hosmer & Lemshow $\chi^2(8) = 6.78$, $p = 0.56$.

** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

mary motivator for visiting film locations. Tourists generally happen to be at a destination, and film is one of many reasons for the visit. It appears that film-induced tourism tends to be an incidental or serendipitous tourist activity. Travel is an added bonus and may help tap into the novelty motivation expressed in the reported research. Thus, clever promotion, packaging, and marketing need to be considered to tap into a potentially lucrative market segment. There are only a very small percentage of tourists who could be classified as specific film-induced tourists who travel to a location for the prime reason of visiting a film site, that is, the main reason for travel is specifically film-related. This identification of such a small specialist segment is consistent with other research findings in examining tourist product profiles for the cultural and ethnic tourist markets (see Moscardo & Pearce, 1999) and in research into dark tourism markets by Sharpley (2003).

Film-induced tourism has the ability to offer destinations significant increased tourist awareness and potential visitation, which in turn can stimulate increased revenue and economic development. The tourism industry can appeal to three core motivational factors to entice tourists to a destination when aligning it with film (novelty, prestige, and personalization). Novelty motives might be met by provision of special film-based attractions or activities at the identified film sites such as guided film walks through sites used in the film, so that tourists can engage in something novel and different.

Couldry's (1998, 2000) research supports this notion of the significance of "actually being there"

as being a tourist experience different from the ordinary related to Urry's (1990) tourist gaze concept. If film constructs a gaze for an individual to observe, visiting the location of that film provides the novel and unique tourism experience for some people.

In terms of appealing to prestige-type motives, destinations could provide photo opportunities through signage identifying scenes/icons from films, and souvenir shops could provide film memorabilia purchasing opportunities. Beeton (2005) provides the example of film-induced tourists who take home a range of stories of their film tourism experiences that raise them up in the view of their peers. Indeed, this important tourist motivation of prestige and ego enhancement has been discussed in the motivation literature since the 1970s (Crompton, 1979; Dann, 1981; MacCannell, 2002). Taking photos was an important activity with nearly 22% of respondents indicating they took photos at a film site.

Although its mean ranking was lower than the other two motivation themes, Personalization elements should not be neglected and destinations should provide opportunities for tourists to make a personal connection with the film. For example, props and icons from films could be made accessible so that individuals may relive scenes from the film and fulfill fantasies of being in the film. It is clearly important to some tourists to make a connection with the film and see the scenery and locations of the film.

The most likely market to engage in future film-induced tourism are those that have already had a film-based trip in the past and who have

high novelty and high personalization motivations. Despite the small niche it occupies, it would be useful for film tourism destinations to also tap into this dedicated film-induced tourist market segment. They have been film-induced tourists before with a desire to experience the film location; based on this study, they are more than likely to be film-induced tourists again.

Limitations

Like all research, the present study had limitations. First, the sampling frame used for this study included individuals who had identified interest in both cinema attendance and travel pursuits. Thus, it could be considered a biased group. However, it was used in this study because we wanted to focus specifically on highly interested respondents. A broader sampling of the wider population might be useful in the future.

Another limitation of this research was the underrepresentation of male respondents. As is common with many consumer surveys (Rourke & Lakner, 1989), there was an underrepresentation of male respondents with a clearly female-dominated sample population with females representing 80%. However, the response rate was very good, and the qualitative responses in particular provided a great deal of rich and detailed information because the respondents had an interest in the topic area.

Conclusion

This article discussed results from research that was conducted to discover possible relationships between film viewing and tourist behavior. It has highlighted some of the key motivations leading to film-induced tourism, including novelty aspects relating to having a unique or novel experience by visiting film locations; prestige aspects, such as the inherent status symbol of film-induced tourism; and personalization (experiential) aspects of film and the sense of personal involvement with film. Indeed, it seems that to physically *be* in the place of the moving image is a strong motivation for the film-induced tourist.

This article also provided empirical evidence that film is a secondary motivator or contributing factor, not a primary motivator, for visiting film

locations. Tourists generally happen to be in a film destination anyway, and film is one of many reasons for the film site visit. Thus, for the vast majority of travelers, film-induced tourism tends to be incidental or serendipitous. Finally, this article concluded that membership of the *likely to take a film-induced tourism holiday in the future* group was most probable among respondents who had taken a film-based holiday in the past and had high novelty and high personalization motivations.

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